

Saregama Carvaan Gold

One wouldn't be wrong in saying that the Carvaan line of music players has done incredibly well – Saregama's profits have reportedly jumped by 233% backed by Carvaan sales. Earlier this year, Saregama announced a collaboration with Harman Kardon to release a higher end model of the standard Carvaan with Harman Kardon speakers. Just like the original, the Carvaan Gold is also packed with 5000 songs now categorized into 130 stations that the listeners can switch between with a dial on the face of the player, as well as a connected app available on both Android and iOS. It also comes with the original feature set of Bluetooth, USB playback support and FM connectivity. The app lets you create custom playlists that can then be programmed into the Carvaan. However, what has made the Carvaan work so well is the convenience of listening to music that it offers, so it is unlikely that its intended target audience will find the app too useful.

Right out of the box, it is quite evident that the Carvaan Gold has been designed to offer a more premium experience than the standard Carvaan. We got the Rose Gold edition while the alternative would be the Champagne Gold model. The device looks absolutely stunning with a shiny finish on all the buttons and dials. The device packs 5 two watt speakers from Harman Kardon that can get really loud without losing clarity. We tried out a bunch of retro songs from Lata Mangeshkar, Mohd Rafi, Kishore Kumar and the Carvaan Gold didn't disappoint on any of these. However,



with Bluetooth playback, we could discern a certain lack of power in the lows, especially evident with pop tracks like *Uptown Funk* by Bruno Mars. However, vocal centric tracks like *Hello* by Adele sounded quite well considering the kind of music this device is actually designed for. There's a strange issue with the design of the device – there's no way to pause the music playback on the device itself. You'll have to use the controls on the included remote or the app (after you've connected it) to be able to pause the music for any reason. This is a significant issue considering the target audience for this device, which is not going to be super keen on using an additional remote or app to perform a basic functionality. Apart from that one issue, we would recommend it as a good gift for fans of retro Bollywood music.

PRICE: ₹14,990/-

FiiO M3K

For a beginner audiophile, purchase decisions are never easy. You know that you're stepping into the big games, probably don't have a significant budget, and the internet is filled with opinions that confuse you in all directions. It almost seems like the FiiO M3K has been designed to allay the fears of these audiophiles. Offering quite a decent level of performance, it is quite light on the pocket and equally easy to use. You get a nice build, impressive battery life, and an admirably smooth enough system UI experience. Sporting a flush unibody all-aluminium design that has almost become FiiO's signature in its devices, the M3K goes for minimalism. The device is quite small and lightweight.

The overall feel is quite similar to the second gen FiiO X1. The Ingenic X1000E



SoC ensures smooth operations. The device boots up in seven seconds, ready to be used. We didn't experience any lag whatsoever during our usage. The FiiO M3K produces an expected flat response, with a slight lean towards brighter notes that is almost imperceptible. The sound-staging and imaging capabilities of the DAP is also impressive, creating a significantly neutral signature that doesn't let much noise in and provides a quieter background to your high-resolution music. It drove our testing units, the Logitech UE 900 and the Beyerdynamic DT 240 Pro with equal ease across a range of tracks spread wide across genres.

Overall, the M3K is a considerable performer at its close to ₹6K price point, and we couldn't recommend a DAP with a better audio performance for budding audiophiles. For the asking price, the FiiO M3K is a no-brainer.

PRICE: ₹5,990/-